might be misleading or lead to erroneous conclusions. I felt, however, that his simplified account of the Einstein field equation of general relativity did need a qualification that he did not quite give. For in Einstein's theory, the "active" mass which is the source of gravity is not simply the same as the energy (according to Einstein's $E=mc^2$); instead, this source is the energy density *plus the sum of the pressures*, and it is this that is the source of gravity's inward accelerations. With this additional qualification, Feynman's account is superb, and provides an excellent introduction to this most beautiful and self-contained of physical theories.

While Feynman's lectures are unashamedly aimed at those who have aspirations to become physicists—whether professionally or in spirit only—they are undoubtedly accessible also to those with no such aspirations. Feynman strongly believed (and I agree with him) in the importance of conveying an understanding of our universe—according to the perceived basic principles of modern physics—far more widely than can be achieved merely by the teaching provided in physics courses. Even late in his life, when taking part in the investigations of the *Challenger* disaster, he took great pains to show, on national television, that the source of the disaster was something that could be appreciated at an ordinary level, and he performed a simple but convincing experiment on camera showing the brittleness of the shuttle's O-rings in cold conditions.

He was a showman, certainly, sometimes even a clown; but his overriding purpose was always serious. And what more serious purpose can there be than the understanding of the nature of our universe at its deepest levels? At conveying this understanding, Richard Feynman was supreme.

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